



BURNING ROW: A torched house in Orrisa

Minority Manoeuvres

DELHI This is how the BJP and the Congress play the game. On the day that ethnic clashes broke out in Assam, the BJP held a press conference in the capital, targeting the Congress Government in the state. The Congress held its daily briefing the

same day, castigating the BJD-BJP Government in Orissa for the attacks on Christians. When asked why she was silent on the Assam issue, Congress spokesperson Jayanti Natarajan said that she was open to questions even if it was not part of

her original briefing. On the other side of the political divide, when asked whether he was not concerned about Orissa, BJP leader Venkaiah Naidu retorted that he was worried about the entire country, from Assam onwards.

Both sides are walking on eggshells as far as the minority question is concerned. Let alone the Opposition and allies like

the Samajwadi Party, even Congressmen are critical of the Batla House encounter in Jamia Nagar. Congress leaders Salman Khurshid and Kapil Sibal (whose constituency in Delhi has a large Muslim representation) made a low-profile visit to Jamia Nagar to express solidarity while party General Secretary Digvijay Singh is said to have expressed his reservations over the incident to party President Sonia Gandhi.

Keeping its NDA allies in mind, the BJP is distancing itself from its hardline wings, the VHP and the Bajrang Dal, after the attacks on Christians in Karnataka. Naidu refused to give a straight answer when asked what the BJP's relationship with the Bajrang Dal is. The time for straight talk is over. It's over to vote-bank politics. **by Priya Sahgal**

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The Government is calling a National Integration Council meeting early next week to discuss communal violence since it lacks the numbers in Parliament to push through President's rule in NDA-ruled Orissa and Karnataka.

VOICES



"The NDA government did not bow before the United States after the Pokhran explosions, but the UPA dispensation did."

L.K. Advani, BJP's prime ministerial candidate

"India has never been a threat to Pakistan. I, for one, and our democratic Government is not scared of Indian influence abroad."

Asif Ali Zardari, Pakistan President

"No right-thinking people are happy with the withdrawal of the Nano project. We have lost one battle, but the war is not lost. We want to raise our head again."

Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, West Bengal chief minister

"We don't mind the scrutiny but when it is done really rubbishly and the way it has been portrayed, then it hurts."

Anil Kumble, India Test cricket captain

"Films are a reflection of what you are. I am not the bubbly NRI girl anymore."

Preity Zinta, actor

